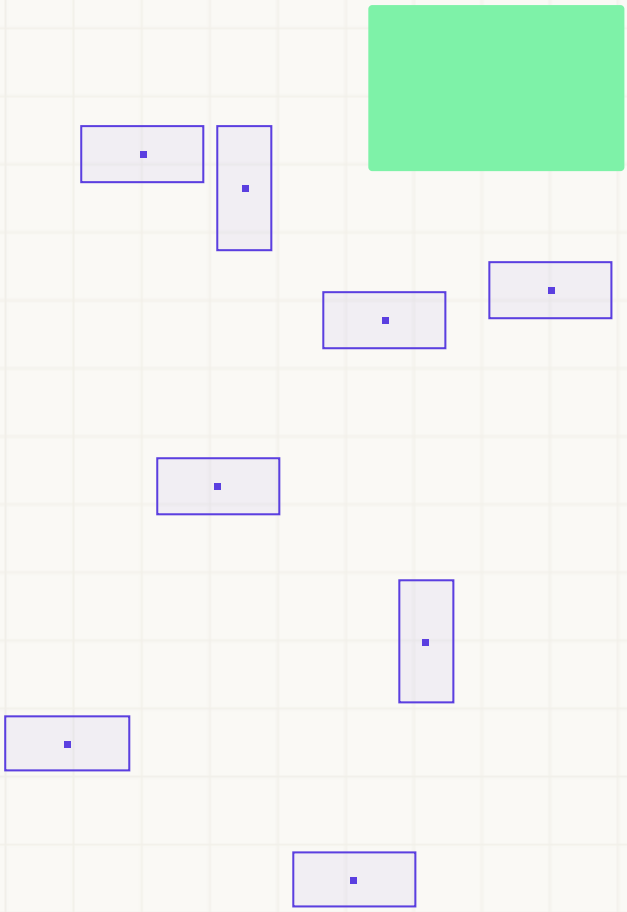
LAAI | AI FOR CONSTRUCTION



# AI tools for construction: a practical map

Which kinds of AI tools exist for architecture offices, builders, estimators and developers, what each one is good for, and when a custom tool is the better choice.

INSIDE

8 tool categories with real examples, a buy-or-build guide and a tool scorecard

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CHECKED

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EIGHT KINDS OF TOOLS

# There is no single AI tool for construction. There are eight kinds.

Most companies do not need all of them. Start with the category that matches the task costing you the most hours, and add others later.

| CATEGORY | WHAT IT DOES | EXAMPLES | BEST FOR |
|---|---|---|---|
| **General AI assistants** Page 03 | Write, summarise, translate, answer questions about documents | Claude, ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini | Everyone |
| **Scripting and automation** Page 04 | Write and fix scripts for Rhino, Grasshopper, Revit and Dynamo | Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, RhinoMCP | Offices with a BIM or design technology person |
| **Inside your design software** Page 04 | AI features and plugins inside Revit, Rhino and Grasshopper | Autodesk Assistant, SmartHopper | Teams already on Revit or Rhino |
| **Feasibility and early design** Page 05 | Generate and compare site layouts, unit mixes and massing | Autodesk Forma, TestFit, Archistar | Developers and housing architects |
| **Visualisation** Page 05 | Turn massing or models into images in seconds | Veras | Competitions and client meetings |
| **Quantities and estimating** Page 06 | Measure areas and counts from drawings or models | Togal.AI, Beam AI, STACK | Estimators and contractors |
| **Documents and contracts** Page 07 | Search project documents, review contracts and submittals | Trunk Tools, Document Crunch | Larger contractors |
| **Site and progress** Page 07 | Capture the site with 360° photos and compare it with the plan or BIM | OpenSpace, Buildots | Contractors on larger sites |

Tools named in this guide are examples, not endorsements. LAAI has no commercial relationship with any of them. AI tools change fast: features were checked in October 2026, so confirm current features, prices and data terms with each vendor.

WHERE EVERYONE STARTS

# General AI assistants: the everyday tools

Chat-based assistants read and write text, and many also read PDFs, images and spreadsheets. In construction they save time on documents long before anyone touches a model.

| TOOL | WHAT IT DOES | GOOD FIT FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Claude (Anthropic)** | Long documents, careful writing, and Claude Code for programming | Reports, tenders, scripts |
| **ChatGPT (OpenAI)** | General writing, images and data analysis | General office work |
| **Microsoft Copilot** | Works inside Word, Excel, Outlook and Teams | Offices on Microsoft 365 |
| **Gemini (Google)** | Works inside Gmail, Docs and Drive | Offices on Google Workspace |

## Good first uses

- ☐ Summarise a tender or specification before the kick-off meeting
- ☐ Draft reports, method statements and client emails
- ☐ Translate documents for international projects
- ☐ Turn meeting notes into a list of actions and owners

## Use them well

- ☐ Give context: project type, standard, audience and the format you want
- ☐ Use a business plan whose terms exclude training on your data
- ☐ Check every number, standard and reference before it leaves the office
- ☐ Pick one assistant for the company, so habits and rules are shared

WHERE THE BIGGEST SAVINGS ARE

# AI that writes tools for your own software

This is the category I use most. AI coding assistants write and fix scripts for Rhino, Grasshopper, Revit and Dynamo, so repetitive drafting, counting and checking can become one-click tools that follow your own standards.

| TOOL | WHAT IT DOES | GOOD FIT FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Claude Code** | An AI coding assistant that writes, runs and fixes scripts with you | Rhino / Python and Revit tools |
| **GitHub Copilot** | Code suggestions inside the code editor | Teams that already write code |
| **RhinoMCP (McNeel, 2026)** | Lets AI assistants work directly inside Rhino | Rhino offices |
| **Grasshopper AI plugins** | SmartHopper (open source), Kea and Planaria help build definitions and scripts | Parametric design teams |
| **Autodesk Assistant (Revit 2027)** | Answers questions about the model and runs tasks; Autodesk describes several features as early or experimental | Revit teams |

## What this looks like in practice

- ☐ **Plan hatching and area schedules** for every apartment in one click
- ☐ **Module and quantity reports** straight from the 3D model to Excel and PDF
- ☐ **A live model check** that flags naming and production errors before export
- ☐ These are among the ~30 tools I built with AI. The assistant writes the code; a person who knows the work decides what to build and checks the result.

THE FIRST WEEKS OF A PROJECT

# Compare more options, earlier

Feasibility tools generate site layouts, unit mixes and parking in minutes. Visualisation tools turn a rough massing into an image a client understands. Both are strongest at the start of a project, when decisions are cheap to change.

| TOOL | WHAT IT DOES | GOOD FIT FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Autodesk Forma** | Site design, massing and early environmental analysis; now connected to Revit | Architects using Autodesk |
| **TestFit** | Generates and compares building layouts, unit mixes and parking | Housing developers |
| **Archistar** | Site feasibility and automated building assessment for cities | Developers; mainly Australia and English-speaking markets |
| **Veras (EvolveLAB)** | AI renderings inside Revit, Rhino, SketchUp, Archicad and Forma | Competitions and early client meetings |

## Watch out for

- ☐ Local rules: most feasibility tools do not know Spanish planning rules (PGOU, CTE) out of the box
- ☐ AI images can show things that cannot be built: label them as concepts
- ☐ Generated layouts still need an architect's judgement on quality

## A custom alternative

- ☐ If you repeat one building system, such as a timber module, a parametric model of that system can give unit counts, areas and early cost per plot in days
- ☐ It follows your rules and your products, which generic tools cannot

FROM DRAWINGS TO NUMBERS

# AI takeoff: fast, but check the result

AI takeoff tools detect rooms, walls and elements on PDF drawings and measure them automatically. They save estimators many hours, but they produce quantities, not prices: your cost data and judgement still turn them into a bid.

| TOOL | WHAT IT DOES | GOOD FIT FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Togal.AI** | AI takeoff on PDF drawings: detects, measures and compares plan versions | Commercial projects, high volumes |
| **Beam AI** | Automated takeoff from uploaded drawings, delivered as a service | Teams short on estimator hours |
| **STACK** | Takeoff and estimating platform with AI features | Contractors who want one platform |
| **Procore (built-in AI)** | AI takeoff and assistants inside the project management platform | Companies already on Procore |

## Before you buy

- ☐ Test on one of your own past projects where you know the right answer
- ☐ Dense, complex or non-English drawings usually need more manual cleanup
- ☐ Accuracy and speed figures are vendors' own claims

## If you already have a 3D model

- ☐ Measuring from the model is usually more exact than detecting elements on a PDF
- ☐ A script can read every element, group identical types and report what it skips
- ☐ This is how my module and facade reports work, with no manual counting

PAPERWORK AND THE JOB SITE

# Tools for documents, contracts and progress

These tools read thousands of pages of project documents, flag risky contract clauses, or compare 360° site photos with the plan. Most are built and priced for larger contractors, often in the US, so check language support and cost before you start.

| TOOL | WHAT IT DOES | GOOD FIT FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Trunk Tools** | Answers questions across project documents and automates submittals | Large contractors |
| **Document Crunch (Trimble)** | Reviews construction contracts and flags risky clauses; acquired by Trimble in 2025 | Contract and commercial teams |
| **OpenSpace** | 360° photo capture of the site, linked to the plan, for documentation | Site teams that need fast records |
| **Buildots** | Compares site captures with the BIM model to track progress and delays | BIM-driven contractors |

## A smaller first step

- [ ] A general assistant on a business plan can already summarise specifications, compare two contract versions and draft RFIs
- [ ] Keep the final review of contracts with your legal or commercial team
- [ ] Move to a specialised platform once the volume of documents justifies it

OFF THE SHELF OR CUSTOM

# When to buy a tool, and when to build one

With AI writing most of the code, small custom tools now cost far less than they used to. That changes the old rule of always buying software.

| IF… | THEN | FOR EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| The task is the same in every company (writing, summarising, translating) | BUY | A general assistant |
| A mature product exists and fits your software and language | BUY | Try it on a real project first |
| The task depends on your own standards, layers, naming or products | BUILD | A custom script or panel |
| You combine tools no product connects (for example Rhino to your cost sheet) | BUILD | A small tool between them |
| The volume is too small to justify an enterprise licence | BUILD | A simple tool you own |
| You are not sure yet where the hours go | NEITHER YET | Map the process first |

### What you get when you buy

- ☐ Support, updates and a product others already use
- ☐ But: a subscription per person, the vendor's workflow, and your data on their platform

### What you get when you build

- ☐ A tool that follows exactly how your office works, and code you own
- ☐ But: someone has to own it, document it and keep it working

CHOOSING A TOOL

# Seven questions before you pay for any AI tool

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 01 | Data terms: is your data excluded from training, and where is it stored? | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 02 | Fits your software: Rhino, Revit, Archicad, Excel, your file formats | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 03 | Works with your language and standards (Spanish drawings, CTE, local units) | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 04 | Tested on one of your real projects, not only the vendor's demo | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 05 | Real cost: per person, per month, plus training time | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 06 | Exit: can you export your data and leave easily? | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 07 | Someone in your team will own it and use it every week | ☐ Yes ☐ No |

SCORECARD · RATE EACH TOOL FROM 1 TO 5

| CRITERION | TOOL A | TOOL B | CUSTOM TOOL |
|---|---|---|---|
| Data terms | | | |
| Fits our software | | | |
| Language and standards | | | |
| Result on our project | | | |
| Real cost | | | |
| Easy exit | | | |
| Owner in the team | | | |
| **Total** | | | |

NEXT STEP

# Not sure which tool fits your company?

I'm Lavinia Lorena Jilavu, a BIM expert in Málaga. I helped bring AI into daily work at a modular timber company and built around 30 tools with it. I can help you:

- ☐ **Find the right category** for the task that costs you the most hours, as part of a workflow audit.
- ☐ **Test tools on your own projects** before you buy, using the scorecard in this guide.
- ☐ **Build the custom tools** that no product offers, tested on your files and yours to keep.
- ☐ **Train your team** to use AI assistants well, in Spanish, English or Italian.

## Book a free first session

Half a day on one of your real tasks, with no commitment.

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